In 480 BCE, the Greeks overthrew the Persians and facilitated the development of artistic styles with the growth of a stable economy. Athens quickly rose to become the strongest player in the ancient world. It established a mighty navy and demanded tributes from various city-states around the Greek world. Athens also created the Delian League and named it after the island of Delos. The League consisted of a coalition of allies ready to defend each other from the Persians should they attempt to invade once more.

However, Sparta, the formidable military state to the south in Laconia, quickly established its own league because it did not trust Athens. The Peloponnesian League was named after the region where Sparta and many of its allies were located. It viewed Athens as a dictator state and a potential threat. The tension between Athens and Sparta resulted in the Peloponnesian Wars. The first war (460 – 445 BCE) concluded with a truce, whereas the second (431 – 404 BCE) resulted in Athens being destroyed by Sparta. However, Sparta celebrated only a bitter victory because it was left severely weakened.

This period is generally known as the Late Classical Period. With Sparta and Athens no longer wielding any true power, a void was left to be occupied by a rising power from the north. Philip II of Macedon was able to defeat Athens at the Battle of Chaeronea in 338 BCE and brought all of the Greek city-states under his rule. Two years later he was assassinated and it was his son Alexander who would lead the Greeks back into power.